

Borenstein/Mostkoff Family Genealogy

Beginning during the dark days of the Covid-19 pandemic of 2020, I was looking for a new genealogy project. My own family tree had reached the point of several dead ends and in frustration, I started asking questions about Philip's family. His family had always intrigued me, but I knew almost nothing about his history beyond the fact that he and his parents were born in Mexico. He knew a bit more, and had done some pieces already many years ago. Those notes became very helpful as a starting point.

In my ignorance, I assumed that tracing Philip's family would follow the familiar pattern of searching records that I was already quite used to- birth, marriage, death. I had no idea when I began, just how difficult it is to trace Eastern European Jewish families prior to WWII and the curiosities I would find about family migration, shtetl life, and odds and ends of a family moving through several countries and languages.

In our Borenstein/Mostkoff family history- naming conventions were (and remain) one of the most difficult bottlenecks in tracing this family. Others include the fact that many records were destroyed, gravesites desecrated and official immigration records are almost non-existent. The fact that forced migration and border movements due to pogroms and political upheavals meant that a family who started in Belarus, ended up in Poland, and then to Mexico (and sometimes to the United States).

An individual may have several names, spelled several different ways, and even though he or she may have been born in Poland, at some point the records may be in Russian. Researching and understanding the movement through the Pale of Settlement is key to understanding Jewish genealogy before 1920.

A person's name is the starting point for genealogy. In these families, a person may have a Hebrew name, a secular name, a Yiddish name, and a nickname which may combine any of the three. In addition, patronymic names were used in place of surnames, and a mother's patronymic was often added to a child's name in both Eastern Europe and in Mexico. Therefore a name such as Ephraim Fishel could be indexed as any of the following:

Efraim Fizel, Fraim, Froim, Efrom, Fischele, Felipe, and many other variations in spelling of any or all of them.

(NB: I also found Efraim Fishel indexed as Peroim Pizzel, so adding transcription errors to the mix made things even muddier)

Women mostly kept their patronymic name after marriage, and added their husband's name. Therefore a name such as Ana Moskoff Linares would make Ana the daughter of Mr. Moskoff and Ms. Linares. When she married, she became Ana Moskoff de Borenstein. Some transcriptions list her before marriage as Ana Linares. Both names must be searched. In addition, her son Philip, has been indexed as "Felipe Moskoff", "Felipe Moskoff Borenstein", Felipe M. Borenstein, as well as his "american" name Philip. Her daughter Edna can be found as both Edna and Jaye, with the names switched from index to index.

As of April 2020, I've barely begun to scratch the surface of this Borenstein/Moskoff family tree. I encourage anyone with information, stories and pictures to submit them and I'm happy to add them.

Generally when putting together a family history, I start as far back as I can and come forward to the present. With these family lines, that's a bit difficult to do so far, so have patience. New records are coming online all the time, and this history will be amended from time to time. I've added my notes and thoughts as to how I arrived at certain information, but this is always subject to change as records are found.

NB: If a different spelling is shown for family names, it's because of vagaries in transcription or translation.

HISTORY AND PLACES OF INTEREST

[Belarus](#) [Minsk](#) was annexed by Russia in 1796 as a consequence of the second partition of Poland. It has also been a part of Lithuania, Austria and Prussia. Searching for records, depends on the time period.

Minsk 1918

The Russian Empire (1772-1917)

As a result of the division of **Rzecz Pospolita** into three parts, Belarus land became part of the Russian Empire. In these new territories the Russian Government started to pursue a policy of russification.

1794 to the First World War – a string of conflicts including:

- **Revolt under Tadeusz Kostushko's leadership** (1794)
- **Napoleonic invasion of Russia** (1812)
- **Polish Revolt** (1830 – 1831)
- **Great Rebellion, headed by Kastus Kalinowski** (1863-1864)

In the **1880s** the revolutionary organisation **Gomon** was established by Belarusian students in Saint Petersburg. This was the precursor to the **first Belarusian national political party** Gromada, formed in **1903**.

In **1906** the **Stolypin agrarian reform** began. **Mass displacement** of the peasant classes (from 1906 – 1916) saw more than 33,000 move from Belarusian territory to Siberia.

World War 1 (1914-1918)

1915 - 1916 – Belarusian territory was the scene of bloody battles between German and Russian forces.

3rd March 1918 – signing of the **Treaty of Brest-Litovsk**, marking Belarus' exit from World War One. The Belarusian territories were occupied by German forces until 1918.

Revolution in Russia (1917-1919)

March 1917 – Revolution in Russia resulted in the abdication of Tsar Nicholas II.

November 1917 – **Bolsheviks** seized power in Russia.

March 1918 – the Belarusian People's Republic declared independence. This lasted until the German withdrawal later that year.

1 January 1919– creation of the **Belarusian Soviet Socialist Republic**.

Russo-Polish War (1919-1921)

1921 – the **Riga Peace Treaty** resulted in the partitioning of Belarus between the **Belarusian Soviet Socialist Republic** and **Poland**.

1921-1941

1921-1928 – New Economic Policy (NEP) introduced across Belarus.

1921-1930s – the Polish part of Belarus subjected to Polonisation.

1922 – Belarusian SSR became a part of the Union of the **Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR)**.

1932-1933 – **famine** brought about by Soviet economic policy and introduction of **collective farming** (*Kolkhoz*).

1936-1940 – the **Great Purge**. More than 86,000 Belarusians suffered political oppression and over 28,000 were sentenced to death at Kuropaty camp near Minsk.



Slutsk Synagogue

Belarus: [Slutsk](#). Slutsk was a town in the Minsk district of Belarus. Accordingly, someone may state that they were from [Slutsk](#), or they may say they were from Minsk, which would have been the larger metro area. A slice of what it was like to live in Slutsk can be found in the translated [Yizkor book](#) by Nissan Waxman. Almost all Jewish citizens of Slutsk were killed in October 1941 and the cemetery was destroyed. See also [Kehila Links](#)

Mostkoff Family Genealogy

POLAK/BORUCHOVICH

The Mostkoff family begins with Y' Mikhal Polak, born about 1838 in [Minsk, Belarus](#). Mikhal married _____. I'm not sure what the "Y" means. It may be that Mikhal's Hebrew name was Yisrail or Yehuda or the "Y" is shorthand for an honorific. Mikhal had at least three children:

Son, Ary Lieb (b: _____, died 13 Jan 1895).

Daughter, Tsietta (b: _____, married Kalman Osher Basin, died 31 March 1912)

A daughter, **Pesheh (also Pessia and Pesha)** (b: _____, died 1 April 1922); married (Abraham) **Nakhman Barukovitch**

The three children were all buried in the Pinkas of the [Chevra Kadisha Cemetery](#) in Slutsk, Belarus. The burial record books are the only records that remain- no burial stones ([matzevah](#)) survived the Shoah. From those burial records the family can be pieced together below:

On Sunday, the seventeenth of Tevet, (13 January 1895) passed away the rabbi mh"r r' **ARY' LEIB**, the son of rabbi mh"r r' **Y' MIKHAL POLAK**, the "melamed" of "talmud tora", and he rests one grave away from AHARON who passed away on Wednesday, the eighth of Adar a' of the year 5654, (14 February 1894) in row "five", to the town side.

On Sunday the thirteenth day of Nisan (31 March 1912) passed away the important venerable woman Mrs. **TSIETA** the daughter of the rabbi mh"r r' **Y' MIKHAL POLAK** the wife of the rabbi mh"r r' **KALMAN OSHER BASIN** and she rests one grave away from the woman Mrs. DVORA who passed away on the fourth day of the aforementioned Tevet (25 December 1911) row "one" across the "maids" b"k to the south side.

Probable children of Tsietta and Kalman Basin are Mendel and Sora

On the holy day of Shabat the third day of Nisan (1 April 1922) passed away the woman Mrs. **PESHEH** the daughter of the rabbi mh"r r' **Y' MIKHAL POLAK** the wife of r' **NAKHMAN BARUKHOVITCH**. She rests by the woman Mrs. ZLATEH who passed away on Wednesday the tenth day of the aforementioned Shvat (8 February 1922) row "twenty-seven" b"k south side

Children: Shifra, Etle, Malka, Mikhal and Beila. [Beila married Shlomo Jonas](#). (See Boruckovich Family below)

BORUKHOVICH

Abraham Nakhman Borukovich (also Boruckovich, Barukovitz, Berkowitz) Nakhman was born probably between 1828 and 1858 (based on his daughter Chifra's birthdate of about 1878) and died in 1918. It appears that he is probably the son of Yosef Halevy Boruchovich as shown in Nakhman's death notice:

On Monday the eighth day of Shvat (21 January 1918) passed away the elderly mh"r **AVRAHAM** the son of mh"r r' **YOSEF HALEVY BERKOVITS** and he rests by YAKOV who passed away on Thursday the nineteenth day of the aforementioned Tevet (3 January 1918) row "twenty-eight" by "kdoshim" to the south side.

Berkovits and Borukhovich are pronounced nearly the same way, so

Pesheh Polak and **Nakhman Barukovitch** were probably married in either Minsk or Slutsk. Their daughter, Chifra, was born about 1878. Nakhman and Peshah had at least three other children, and possibly a fourth- Beila.

Chifra (born 1878), married Israel Mostkoff prior to 1910

Etle married Samuel Reszik

[Malkah married Faivel Kharakh](#) (Malka was born about 1892)

Mikhail (probably named after Pesheh's father) a/k/a Moise (born about 1916) - married Haya Pastron. If indeed Moisey was given the name Mikhal, it's probable that Pesheh's father was deceased at the time of his birth (1918 if the burial record above is accurate).

Beila married Shlomo Yonas:

On Tuesday the fourth day of Adar a' (4 February 1919) passed away suddenly the venerable woman Mrs. **BEILA** the daughter of mh"r r' **AVRAHAM BARUKHOVITS** the wife of r' **SHLOMO YONUS** and she rests by the woman Mrs. CHAYA-SARA who passed away on the holy day of Shabat the third day of the aforementioned Shvat (4 January 1919) new row "three" by the "kdoshim" to the south side.

You may ask why I think Shifra and Beila were sisters if Shifra's father's name was "Nakhman" and Beila's was "Avraham". It's one of those vagaries in Jewish names that comes up and Nakhman's full name was "Avraham Nakhman"



Beila Boruchovitch Yonus



Yonus Family in Belarus

MOSTKOFF

F. 14
CIO DE MIGRACION
REGISTRO DE EXTRANJEROS

NUM. **19801**
64671

SE EXPIDE EL **20** DE **Mayo** DE 19**30**

A **SR. CHIFRA MOSTKOFF**

MEXICO QUEDA COMPROBADA CON

CONSTITUCION FISICA **fuerte**

ESTATURA **1.60 mt.** COLOR **blanco**

PELO **castaño** CEJAS **castañas**

OJOS **azules** NARIZ **regular**

MENTON **avellano** BIGOTE

BARBA **usa lentes y tiene dientes de oro**

DATOS COMPLEMENTARIOS

EDAD **52** AÑOS. FECHA EN QUE NACIO **1878**

ESTADO CIVIL **casada** PROFESION, OFICIO U

Ocupacion **su hogar**

IDIOMA NATIVO **ruso** OTROS IDIOMAS

QUE HABLE **ruso y poco español**

LUGAR Y PAIS EN QUE NACIO

NACIONALIDAD ACTUAL **rusa**

RELIGION **israelita** RAZA **caucásica**

LUGAR DE RESIDENCIA **San Carlos, Ver.**

NOMBRE Y DOMICILIO EN MEXICO DE PERSONAS QUE PUEDAN DAR RE-

FERENCIAS DEL INTERESADO **St. Maria la Ribera St. Carlos**

QUIEN ENTRO EN MEXICO POR **Veracruz, Ver.**

enero EL **8** DE **1929**

(FIRMA DEL PORTADOR)

Mostkoff Chifra

(FIRMA DEL FUNCIONARIO DE MIGRACION)

N. Jiménez

SELO

chs 689/

Mexican Immigration Card for Chifra Boruchovich Moskoff

MOSTKOFF

Chifra Boruchovich married Israel Mostkoff prior to 1910, likely in Slutsk or Minsk.

Israel Mostkoff, born in 1878 is likely the son of Reuben Mostkoff, and I've found records matching his with a patronymic of Israel Rubinovich. This wouldn't be unusual for records of the time to use the father's name as a surname, but it is not definitive.

The Mostkoff name is an anomaly.